

Game Design Document:

Nature's Reprise

Game Overview:

Description

Nature's Reprise is a puzzle platformer game where players take on the role of a nature guardian leaving the guardians grove. Using their abilities to bring life back into plants, and grow plants where they never were before, the player navigates the platforming puzzles as they explore the forest. After resting for a long time, the player will go on to discover the forest they were just playing through is now ravaged. With more plants dead, natural animals gone, and questions about what is happening, the player must navigate back to the guardian's grove to get answers about what happened, and help to prevent it from happening elsewhere.

Game Style:

The game revolves around the player managing their nature essence to solve platforming challenges that they are faced with. Nature's Reprise has a low skill floor to play, really putting the emphasis on puzzle solving and finding many solutions to a problem in order to make the limited resources the player has last.

Appeals:

The game's mechanics and design will cater to an audience who enjoys platformers where you can have a lot of expression in how you go about solving problems. Players who enjoy more of an implicit narrative about what is going on in the world will find the story of Nature's Reprise a simple, yet relatable tale concerning the resources of the natural world, and climate change effect on the scarcity and need for those resources.

Game Mechanics:

Gameplay Loop:

The player moves through a mostly linear path, with small nooks and offshoots they can explore. As they continue along this path they are faced with platforming challenges that require them to

carefully consider not just the easiest way to solve a problem, but also how to manage their nature essence so that they don't run out, otherwise the platforming puzzles the player face is going to get more difficult to solve and difficult to execute.

Sections of the game are separated out using checkpoints, which the player will return to if they either get hurt or hurt any of nature's creatures. These checkpoints restore nature essence and serve to separate out different platforming sections.

Systems:

Nature Essence: A resource used by the player to activate their abilities

Checkpoints: When players pass this it activates, setting their respawn position to be the checkpoint. As well when they pass it their nature essence is filled completely.

Enemies: There are forest creatures that, when the player accidentally harms, they undo their efforts to redo the situation without harming the creature.

Gem: Follows the player around, serving as an indicator for regeneration ability and reinforcing what the player is.

Leaf Blocks: These blocks detect when the player is standing on them and will break after a moment, turning into Leafless blocks.

Leafless Blocks: These blocks, a few seconds after spawning, will turn into Leaf Blocks

Player Mechanics:

Basic Player Movement: The player can move and jump using both a keyboard and controller as input methods.

Climbing: The player, when within range of a climbable surface indicated with a vine, will begin climbing it. While climbing the player can move up and down and jump off the wall, jumping as if they were on the ground.

Regeneration: The player is able to spend nature essence(usually 1) in order to regenerate specific objects. This causes the object to transform into a different form, giving the player new ways to manoeuvre around the environment. Listed below are the regenerateables in the game, and what they turn into:

- Sapling → Tree: Player can Climb and jump on top of it
- Dead Leaf Block → Leaf Block: Player is has a new platform to stand on

- Mushroom Spores → Mushroom: Bounces the player upwards when touched

Gem Toss: When the ability button is held down, an green arc appears indicating when the ability will be thrown. When the button is released the player character will toss a gem that, if it collides with a wall, will decrease the amount of nature essence the player has and will cover the wall with vines, making it climbable. Otherwise if it collides with a ceiling or floor it will despawn and not remove any player essence in order to not punish players too harshly for mis-aiming a throw.

There is a cooldown between throws so players are not able to use the ability too much in quick succession. As well, the player cannot use the vine toss while wall climbing, in order to encourage either planning out their Gem Tosses before they commit to a plan, or developing the skill of doing gem tosses while airborne.

Narrative:

A nature guardian, younger to the role and with a carefree outlook sought to take a look at the world their kind protected. The name Terra was one that was given to them, as a whole or just to this sole guardian? The answer to that not many could know. They sprung forth from the many great roots that connected them to places all over the world. Allowing for these guardians to come to the aid of the natural order of the places they could reach, keeping a peace most important. Terra was learning about their duties, their obligation and ability to provide care to the world so many creatures resided in. All the knowledge only pushed them to further their curiosity and use one of these great roots to get a look at this world themself.

This is where Terra's journey truly begins, making them put to use what they had learned mostly through teachings and very little practice. Putting these skills to use, they end up finding a truly serene spot fit for the greatest of comforts. A homely tree with an inviting place to rest present to Terra, having put as much energy as they did towards making use of skills that had not seen much wear beforehand.

This long slumber they indulge in comes to a sudden halt when the tree comes crashing down, putting forward a grim visage of a world of nightmares. A land stripped of its beauty, drained of colour and life. Terra steels themself knowing the journey ahead will not be easy but with the ultimate goal to regain this land to its former glory.

At the end of Terra's journey, they see a remnant of an ancient root. Tarnished by the ruined atmosphere, unable to bear use. Terra then musters up all of the nature essence within themselves to regenerate the ancient root and get back to the guardian's grove. Once there Terra then speaks to the other guardians about the situation outside. The nightmare up above that they had witnessed. Calling to the other guardians to aid them in healing the land.

Art Direction:

UI:

Main Menu UI

The main menu of "Nature's Reprise" offers a visually compelling entrance into the game's world. Divided diagonally, the background contrasts a desolate, barren landscape on the left with a vibrant, flourishing ecosystem on the right, symbolising the transformative journey the player is about to undertake. This poignant imagery serves as an allegory for the game's central theme of environmental rejuvenation. Three options: 'Start Game,' 'Options,' and 'Exit Game,' are displayed in a large, pixel art font that echoes the game's retro aesthetic. The main menu not only sets the stage for the narrative but also provides a straightforward navigation experience, with a clear, responsive interface that changes colour to indicate selection, ensuring that the player's interaction is intuitive and immediate.

Options Menu - Audio UI

Delving into the audio settings within the options menu, players are greeted with a minimalist and functional design that allows for precise personalization of the game's sound. The menu is divided into tabs, with the 'Audio' tab presenting sliders for 'Master,' 'Music,' and 'Sound FX' volumes. These sliders provide tangible auditory feedback as they are adjusted, offering a user-friendly approach to sound management. This level of customization ensures that players can balance the audio to their preference, catering to both those who enjoy immersive music and sound effects and those who may require a quieter environment to play.

Options Menu - Display UI

Switching to the 'Display' tab in the options menu, players are presented with critical visual settings that cater to their gameplay experience. With straightforward toggle options for 'V-Sync' and 'Fullscreen,' the game respects the player's need for a customised visual setup. V-Sync can be activated to reduce screen tearing, while Fullscreen mode allows players to immerse themselves completely in the game's pixelated beauty. Each toggle provides instant visual feedback, reassuring players that their preferences have been applied. These options reflect a thoughtful design philosophy that prioritises player comfort and visual performance.

Pause Menu UI

The pause menu is seamlessly integrated into the game's flow, halting the action without jarring the player from the experience. With options to 'Resume,' 'Restart,' 'Options,' or 'Quit,' the menu is a bastion of simplicity, pausing the game and allowing players to make necessary adjustments or take a break. The menu's design echoes the main menu, maintaining visual and operational consistency with the rest of the game. This design decision reinforces familiarity and ease of use, as players navigate through their in-game journey without unnecessary complications.

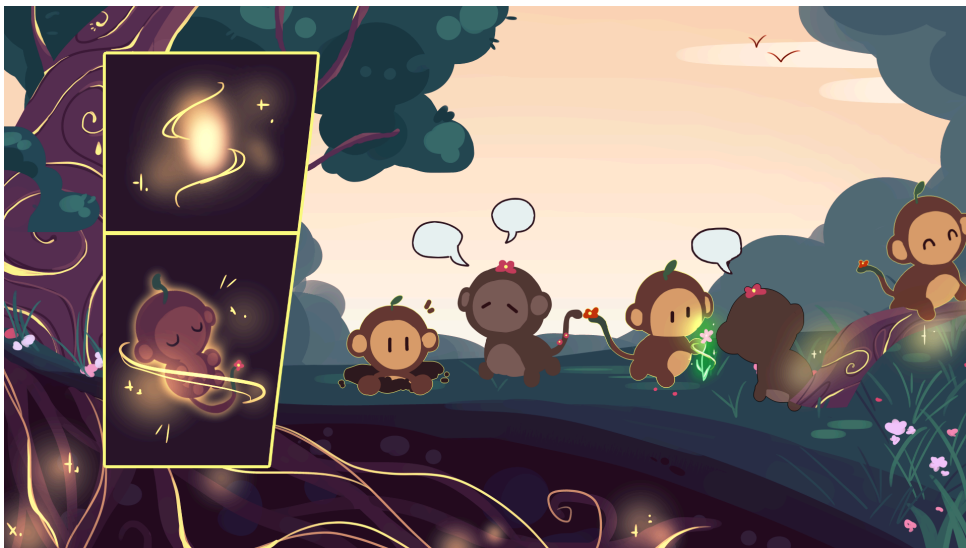
In-Game UI - Gem Usage Display

The in-game UI is meticulously designed to prioritise clarity and accessibility, a philosophy exemplified by the gem usage display positioned in the top-left corner of the screen. This strategic location offers players an at-a-glance inventory check, allowing them to monitor their collected gems without pulling focus from the gameplay. In moments where the pace intensifies, the significance of having an unobtrusive yet clearly legible display becomes paramount. Adhering to well-established gaming conventions, the placement of the gem display aligns with player expectations, ensuring vital information is accessible without distraction.

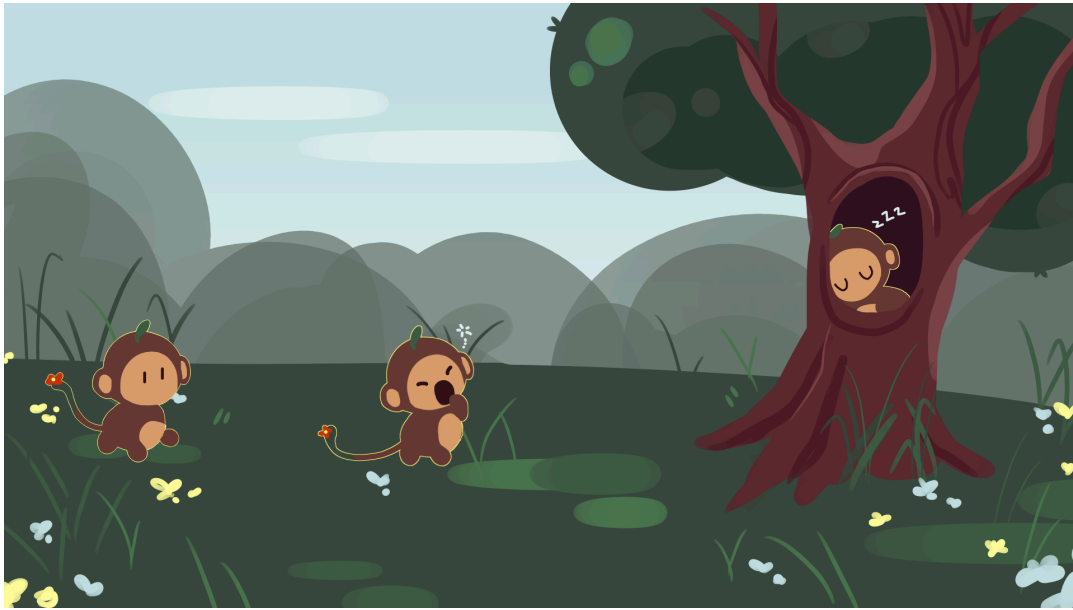
To further enhance the user experience, an interactive feature has been incorporated into the gem display. When a player uses a gem, the corresponding icon on the display will momentarily turn red and flash, providing an immediate and unmistakable visual cue that a gem has been utilised. This flashing not only draws the player's eye, ensuring they are aware of their diminishing resources but also adds a dynamic visual element to the UI. The choice to make the gems flash red is deliberate, leveraging the colour's universal association with alerts and important actions to naturally inform players of their in-game decisions.

Cutscenes:

There are 3 “cutscenes” total within the game: one at the beginning to introduce the player to the narrative, one in the middle to act as a transition between the two levels, and one at the end to wrap up the narrative of the game. All scenes contain a static background with the images of the character changing to depict the story. The first scene shows the birth of the main character in a comic-like panelled style, followed by a series of images of the character popping out of the ground, being taught by a mentor, and finally riding a root to the outside world. This is when the playable first section of the game begins. This scene takes place in the Guardian's Grove, depicted by dream-like colours with trees being more purple and grass being more blue, and a golden sky.



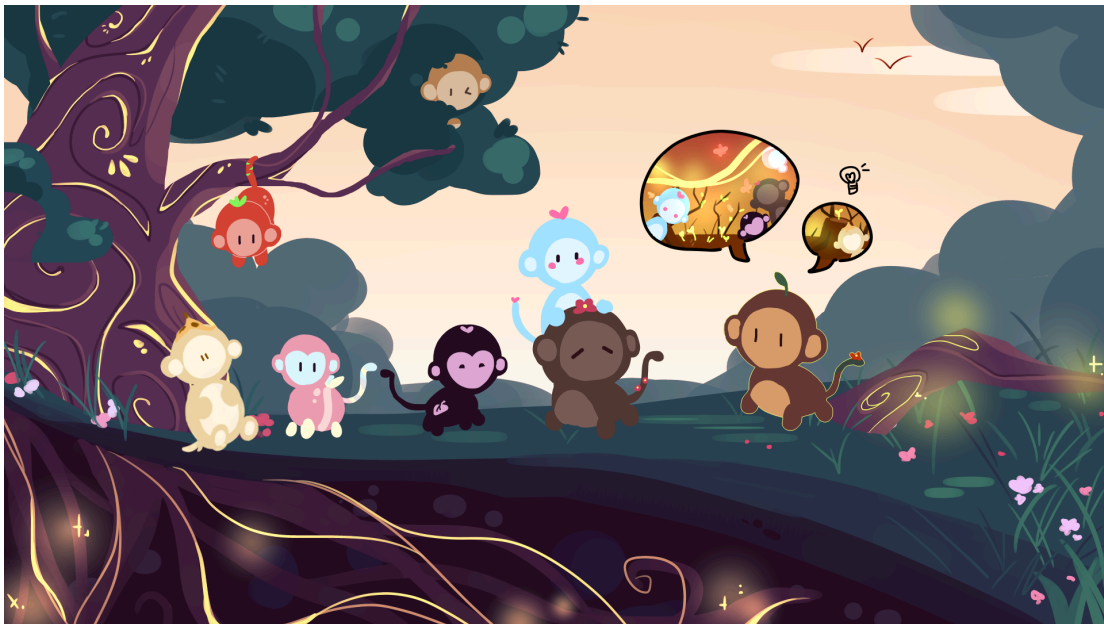
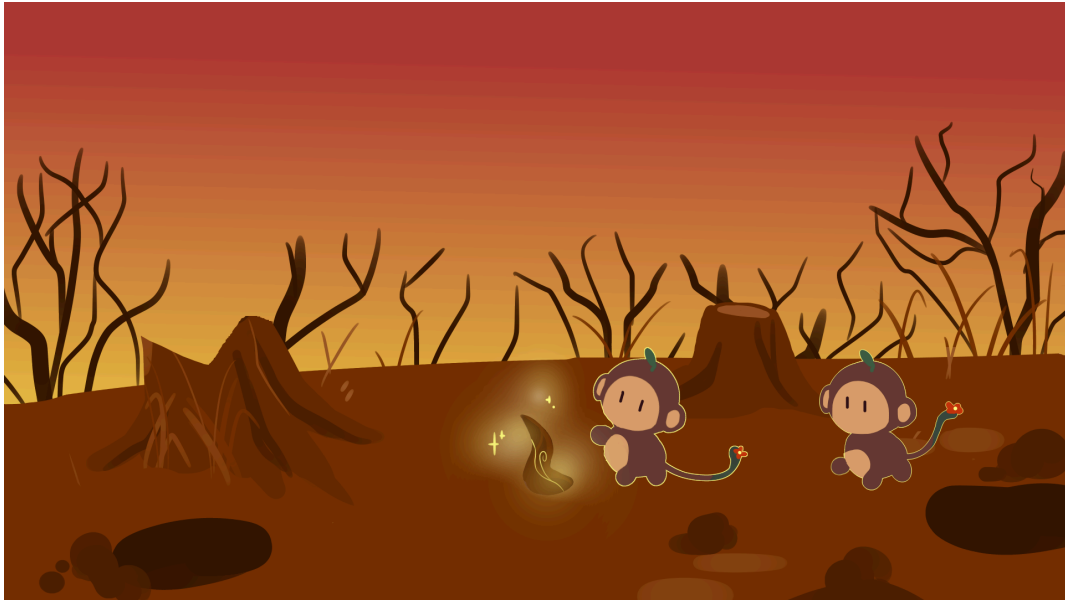
Upon completion of the first playable section, the second scene begins. This one takes place in a lush forest similar to but without the magical elements of the first scene. This one has four frames: the monkey enters the scene, yawns, climbs into the tree and falls asleep.



The screen then fades to black and the background changes to a desolate version of the previous background. The tree cracks and falls over, and Terra falls into a hole. The second playable section then begins with the player in the hole.



The final cutscene occurs after the player completes the second level. Terra, still in the desolate world, creates a magical root. The background then changes to the initial Guardian's Grove, where multiple other monkeys are lounging around, and Terra appears on the magical root. All the monkeys turn around to face Terra, who then tells them about the ruined world and suggests all of them going there to help fix it.



The art style of these cutscenes, being non-pixel with smoother lines, is different from that of the playable aspects to differentiate the two. These cutscenes can be skipped if the player so chooses, but are otherwise automatically controlled.

Art:

The art shows a bright and colourful world for our protagonist to explore, welcoming and full of life. This is contrasted with the more oppressive post-collapse world where many elements have become desaturated and have lost their cool tones, providing contrast when the player regenerates a piece of the environment and brings that coolness and saturation back.

Sound:

The music and sound in the game is used to increase immersion within the game and reinforce what the player character is within the setting. The player makes sounds when jumping, landing, walking and climbing. The walking and climbing sounds are lined up with the animation in order for them to sound more realistic. The bee enemies have a buzzing sound to them that, as the player gets closer, begins to quiet the background music drawing the players attention to the prominent threat around them.

The sound effects for using abilities were chosen because they sounded magical and the music's instrumentation was picked to invoke feelings of wonder, mysticity, and wooded forests. All of the audio was compiled from online sources, and credits for sources that required it are located **in the credits** and in the Music and Sound Effect Folders.